PROJECT CASE STUDY

3LT JOURNAL THEME

A custom editorial identity and responsive journal interface, connecting issue discovery, article reading, and journal information through a cohesive public theme.

PROJECT	THEME SCOPE	STATUS
3LT Scholarly Journal	**Visual Design · Public Pages**	**Deployed**
English Studies	**Responsive UI · Interactions**	**To VPS**

01 The Design Challenge

A journal's public identity is experienced across many pages—not just its homepage. Readers need to recognize the journal, browse its issues, assess an article, and find editorial or submission information without repeatedly learning a new layout.

The 3LT theme needed a scholarly character, clear information hierarchy, and comfortable long-form reading. The design also had to adapt to smaller screens while retaining the existing publishing workflows supplied by Janeway.

> The goal: make 3LT feel like one coherent journal, from the first issue listing to the article page, while keeping the custom work focused on the public experience.

02 The Theme That Was Built

A custom Django sub-theme with a shared editorial shell, page-specific layouts, responsive CSS, and lightweight JavaScript. The work extends well beyond branding to the structure and behavior of the journal's public pages.

VISUAL IDENTITY

Ink-blue, pale-blue, and ochre styling; serif headings; readable text; consistent spacing, borders, navigation, and calls to action.

DISCOVERY & READING

A tailored homepage, current-issue list, year-grouped archives, issue contents, search results, and a scholarly article layout.

JOURNAL INFORMATION

Profile-led editorial sections, structured About/Guidelines, contact presentation, login/register screens, and public error pages.

RESPONSIVE INTERACTIONS

Mobile navigation, collapsible sections, issue jump controls, search filters, and consent preferences within the shared theme.

03 The Reader Experience

The theme organizes the journal around a connected reader journey. A common masthead, navigation, footer, and page language establish continuity; each content type then receives a layout suited to its purpose.

Homepage → Issues & search → Article → Reading & citation

Shared identity → familiar navigation and consistent page structure

Desktop and mobile → adapted content order and interaction patterns

Discover what the journal publishes

The homepage places the journal introduction alongside current-issue content and supporting information. Article rows, publication details, submission entry points, and the Most Read presentation give readers distinct routes into the content.

Browse issues and find a paper

Archives use year-grouped lists rather than a cover-first grid. Issue pages provide a numbered article sequence and jump navigation. Search pages bring query controls, filters, summaries, and empty-state guidance into the same visual language.

Read the article in a scholarly layout

The article page brings authors and affiliations, abstract, keywords, publication details, available files, licensing, and citation actions into a clear hierarchy. The theme presents Janeway’s scholarly data and links without replacing its publishing services.

Move naturally between journal information and action

Editorial profiles, long-form guidelines with in-page contents, contact details, and account-entry screens share the public shell. Readers can move from learning about the journal to registration or submission entry points without an abrupt visual change.

04 Theme Features

- **A restrained editorial visual system** — ink-blue foundations, pale-blue surfaces, ochre accents, Source Serif 4 headings, and Inter/system body text create a consistent scholarly identity.

- **Purpose-built page layouts** — the homepage, archive, issue contents, article, search, editorial board, guidelines, and contact page are composed for their specific reading and navigation needs.

- **Responsive content presentation** — desktop content-and-sidebar layouts adapt for mobile, with reorganized sections, touch-oriented controls, and a dedicated navigation drawer.

- **Lightweight reader interactions** — Escape-close and focus restoration for mobile navigation, expandable journal information, issue navigation, and search-filter disclosure support the responsive layouts.

- **Detailed article presentation** — authorship, affiliations, optional identifier links, abstract, keywords, rights, citation exports, and available galleys are organized within one themed reading surface.

- **Clear empty and recovery states** — search guidance, unavailable-content messages, and custom public error screens keep the experience understandable when readers reach an empty result or an unavailable page.

- **Consistent account and contact surfaces** — custom login/register layouts and contact-form presentation retain Janeway’s form processing, validation, CSRF, and integration hooks.

- **Considered supporting behavior** — print styling, reduced-motion rules, and optional analytics consent controls extend the theme beyond its default screen layout. Analytics loading is gated by a configured property and reader acceptance.

05 Theme Architecture

The custom layer lives in threelt: Django template overrides and shared includes render the public pages, while theme-local CSS and JavaScript supply the visual system and interactions. Janeway provides the external publishing platform.

LAYER	IMPLEMENTATION	ROLE IN THE THEME
Shared shell	Django template inheritance	Public masthead, navigation, footer, messages, and shared page structure.
Page composition	Overrides · reusable includes	Page-specific content, article rows, sidebars, information sections, and recovery states.
Design & layout	Theme-local CSS	Visual tokens, typography, desktop/mobile layouts, article styling, print, and reduced-motion rules.
Interaction layer	Vanilla JavaScript	Mobile navigation, disclosures, filters, and conditional analytics preferences.
Assets & support	Python theme utilities	Copy authored CSS/JS into static paths; automate journal configuration; seed local test data.
Platform boundary	Janeway · OLH base theme	Existing data, routes, forms, and publishing workflows; fallback for unoverridden pages.

Design decisions that matter

One shell, distinct reading surfaces. Reusable includes keep the identity consistent, while article, archive, search, and information pages retain structures appropriate to their content.

Custom public experience, preserved platform workflows. The theme uses Janeway’s data and named routes. Unoverridden templates fall back to OLH/Janeway rather than duplicating the platform.

Tooling supports the theme. The asset builder handles authored styles and scripts, configuration simplifies deployment, and the separate seeder supports local visual testing. These utilities support—not define—the main design contribution.

06 Value Delivered

A distinct public-facing theme that gives 3LT a consistent journal identity and a connected reader experience.

Distinct
EDITORIAL IDENTITY

Responsive
READER EXPERIENCE

Deployed
TO VPS

- **A recognizable identity across the journal.** — The same visual language carries through the homepage, issue discovery, article reading, editorial information, contact, and account-entry surfaces.
- **A more deliberate content hierarchy.** — Current-issue rows, year-grouped archives, numbered issue navigation, scholarly article details, and structured guidelines give different content types clear places within the theme.
- **A consistent experience across screen sizes.** — Responsive layouts and small, purposeful interactions adapt navigation, supporting information, and reading surfaces for desktop and mobile use.
- **A maintainable custom presentation layer.** — Shared templates, reusable includes, and theme-local CSS/JavaScript keep the public design together while Janeway continues to supply the underlying publishing and editorial workflows.

3LT — a deployed journal theme combining a scholarly visual identity, purpose-built public pages, responsive layouts, and thoughtful reader interactions.

CUSTOM DESIGN, BUILT INTO THE JOURNAL

The central contribution is the threelt theme: how the journal looks, how its public content is organized, and how readers move through it. Asset, configuration, and local test utilities support that theme’s delivery and maintenance.